

mometers. Other forms of “meetingware” can enable these tasks. But the key here is that there is no need for technical support. This is practical knowledge management. And weblogs are the perfect tool for keeping the discussion live and on the surface of daily life at the office.

Weblogs are already enabling salespeople to create tighter relationships with customers by establishing ongoing dialogue threads. These threads can be opened up to include more of a customer’s stakeholders on a particular buying decision, or more of the salesperson’s internal advisors. Imagine a salesperson sets up a weblog for each major customer. Every morning, or every week, he or she types a short paragraph into the content field of each weblog - news about product enhancements, troubleshooting tips, upcoming promotions. The customers can read them and respond at their convenience, they feel connected and relevant and have a personal, one-to-one persistent dialogue that can be dropped off and picked up at any time. All the salesperson has to do is check the responses regularly to maintain his or her end of the discussion. This helps in timing new product presentations, identifying issues and potential problems, sharing new industry thinking - all in a format that is as personal as a phone call.

Or take the case of an electronics engineer who is responsible for parts availability in a large company that manufactures patient monitoring devices. He’s part of a team developing a new heart monitor. Using a weblog, he can tap the experience and knowledge of the rest of the company’s engineers, even those in Germany and California, as he goes about designing and subcontracting components for the new device. Before, this type of professional knowledge exchange would be discouragingly time-consuming and disjointed. Now, instead of phoning or emailing one engineer after another until he finds the one with the appropriate knowledge, he can micro-broadcast his weblog to the company’s engineering community at large. The other engineers can answer at their convenience, which makes their participation more likely in the first place, and there’s a forum for productive discussion.